probably the largest of all the ethnic groups in the country. Members of the ethnic group live mainly in southern Lebanon, bordering Israel. This is a minority that was historically weak, poor, and suppressed and whose main livelihood was agriculture. The affinity of members of this group to Iran is based on their religious identity—the Shia faith. According to radical Shiite Islam, a violent conflict that does not end with a crushing defeat or surrender is considered a victory because, according to their belief, war is eternal, and in order to reach the final victory it is enough just to survive the battles on the way to this ultimate triumph. That is how the Shiites in Lebanon interpreted the IDF's evacuation in 2001. For them, it was proof that Israel was not invincible. Iran and Syria's military and other types of assistance to Hezbollah turned the organization into a force that could not be ignored. Over time, Hezbollah became a state within a state. As they increased their military power, they established a political arm that became a party represented in the Lebanese parliament and government coalition.

The Shiite leadership, unlike many others in Lebanon, is not tainted by corruption and expands its influence in the community through social activities, health services, education, and the like. There is no lack of funds for these activities. During the period under discussion, $100 million was transferred to finance them from Iran alone. Despite his simple origins, Hassan Nasrallah proved himself as a charismatic figure and has grown to be the unshakable leader of the Shiites in Lebanon, though his religious title is not particularly illustrious. Nasrallah's ties with Iran go back to the time he studied there and became acquainted with some of its current leadership.

Syria, a country controlled by the Alawite minority, also a Shiite sect, completes the Shiite Crescent, which includes Iran, Iraq, Syria, and Lebanon. Syria was established in the framework of the Sykes-Picot Agreement of 1916, which served as the basis for the political reality dictated by the victors of the First World War. Syria never recognized Lebanon's political sovereignty de jure, seeing it rather as an integral part of Syria, or at the very least as an entity under Syrian strategic influence and control. On Syrian maps, you will not find an international border between Syria and Lebanon. At the current border between the two countries, on the Damascus-Beirut road, there is only a Lebanese border crossing point, manned by Lebanese border policemen and customs. Since the Six-Day War in 1967, when Israel captured the Golan Heights from Syria, not a shot has been fired from the Syrian side of the border toward Israel. Syria has